Reproductive Health

Common Reproductive Health Concerns for Women

MAY 15, 2024

For Everyone

AT A GLANCE

Find information on some common reproductive health concerns such as endometriosis, uterine fibroids, gynecologic cancer, HIV, interstitial cystitis, polycystic ovary syndrome, sexually transmitted infections, and sexual and intimate partner violence.

Endometriosis

Endometriosis is a problem affecting a woman's uterus—the place where a baby grows when a woman is pregnant. Endometriosis occurs when the kind of tissue that normally lines the uterus grows somewhere else. It can grow on the ovaries, behind the uterus, on the bowels, or on the bladder. Rarely, it grows in other parts of the body.

This "misplaced" tissue can cause pain, infertility, and very heavy periods. The pain is usually in the abdomen, lower back, or pelvic areas. Some women have no symptoms at all. For these women, the first sign they have endometriosis may be that they have trouble getting pregnant.

Uterine fibroids

Uterine fibroids are the most common noncancerous tumors in women of reproductive age. Fibroids are made of muscle cells and other tissues that grow in and around the wall of the uterus, or womb. The cause of fibroids is unknown. Risk factors include being African American or being overweight. The symptoms of fibroids include:

- Heavy or painful periods or bleeding between periods.
- Feeling "full" in the lower abdomen.
- Urinating often.
- Pain during sex.
- Lower back pain.
- Infertility.
- Multiple miscarriages.

But some women will have no symptoms.

Gynecologic cancer

Gynecologic cancer is any cancer that starts in a woman's reproductive organs. Gynecologic cancers begin in different places within a woman's pelvis, the area below the stomach and between the hip bones.

- Cervical cancer begins in the cervix, which is the lower, narrow end of the uterus.
- Ovarian cancer begins in the ovaries, which are located on each side of the uterus.
- Uterine cancer begins in the uterus, the pear-shaped organ in a woman's pelvis where the baby grows when a woman is pregnant.
- Vaginal cancer begins in the vagina, which is the hollow, tube-like channel between the bottom of the uterus and the outside of the body.
- Vulvar cancer begins in the vulva, the outer part of the female genital organs.

HIV

HIV is the human immunodeficiency virus. HIV affects specific cells of the immune system (called CD4 cells). Over time, HIV can destroy so many of these cells that the body can't fight off infection anymore.

The human body cannot get rid of HIV—that means once a person has HIV, he or she has it for life. There is no cure at this time, but with proper medical care, the virus can be controlled. HIV is the virus that can lead to acquired immune deficiency syndrome, or AIDS. AIDS is the late stage of HIV infection, when a person's immune system is severely damaged.

HIV in Women

Women who are infected with HIV typically get it by having sex with a man who is infected or by sharing needles with an infected person.

While HIV affects all races and ethnicities in the United States and U.S. territories, some groups are disproportionately affected compared to their population size. Black/African American people and Hispanic/Latino people are particularly affected by HIV. Racism, HIV stigma, homophobia, poverty, and barriers to health care continue to drive these disparities.

Pregnant Women

All pregnant women should know their HIV status. It is possible for a mother to have HIV and not spread it to her baby, especially if she knows about her HIV status early and works with her health care provider to reduce the risk. Pregnant women who are HIV-positive can work with their health care providers to ensure their babies do not contract HIV during pregnancy, delivery, or after delivery (through breast milk).

Learn more from CDC's Let's Stop HIV Together campaign, including how HIV is spread and how to prevent HIV.

Interstitial cystitis

Interstitial cystitis (IC) is a chronic bladder condition resulting in recurring discomfort or pain in the bladder or surrounding pelvic region. People with IC usually have inflamed or irritated bladder walls. This can cause scarring and stiffening of the bladder.

IC can affect anyone; however, it is more common in women than men. People could have some or none of the following symptoms:

- Abdominal or pelvic mild discomfort.
- Frequent urination.
- A feeling of urgency to urinate.
- Feeling of abdominal or pelvic pressure.
- Tenderness.
- Intense pain in the bladder or pelvic region.
- Severe lower abdominal pain that intensifies as the urinary bladder fills or empties.

Polycystic ovary syndrome (PCOS)

Polycystic ovary syndrome happens when a woman's ovaries or adrenal glands produce more male hormones than normal. One result is that cysts (fluid-filled sacs) develop on the ovaries. Women who are obese are more likely to have PCOS. Women with PCOS are at increased risk of developing diabetes and heart disease. Symptoms may include:

- Infertility.
- Pelvic pain.
- Excess hair growth on the face, chest, stomach, thumbs, or toes.
- Baldness or thinning hair.
- Acne, oily skin, or dandruff.
- Patches of thickened dark brown or black skin.

Sexually transmitted infections (STIs)

STIs, also known as sexually transmitted diseases (STDs), are infections that you can get from having sex with someone who has the infection. The causes of STIs are bacteria, parasites, and viruses. There are more than 20 types of STIs. Read more about specific STIs from these CDC fact sheets.

Most STIs affect both men and women, but in many cases the health problems they cause can be more severe for women. If a pregnant woman has an STI, it can cause serious health problems for the baby.

If you have an STI caused by bacteria or parasites, it can be treated with antibiotics or other medicines. If you have an STI caused by a virus, there is no cure, but antiviral medication can help control symptoms. Correct usage of latex condoms greatly reduces but does not eliminate the risk of catching or spreading STIs.

Sexual and intimate partner violence

Sexual violence (SV) is a significant problem in the United States. SV refers to sexual activity where consent is not obtained or freely given. Learn more about preventing sexual violence.

Intimate partner violence (IPV) is a serious, preventable public health problem that affects millions of Americans. The term *intimate partner violence* describes physical, sexual, or psychological harm by a current or former partner or spouse. This type of violence can occur among heterosexual or same-sex couples and does not require sexual intimacy.

Resources

Find a Health Center

Health Resources Services Administration (HRSA) health centers care for you, even if you have no health insurance. You pay what you can afford, based on your income.

SOURCES AND PAGE INFO

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SOURCES

- Health Resources and Services Administration. Find a Health Center. Accessed January 1, 2024. https://findahealthcenter.hrsa.gov/
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